

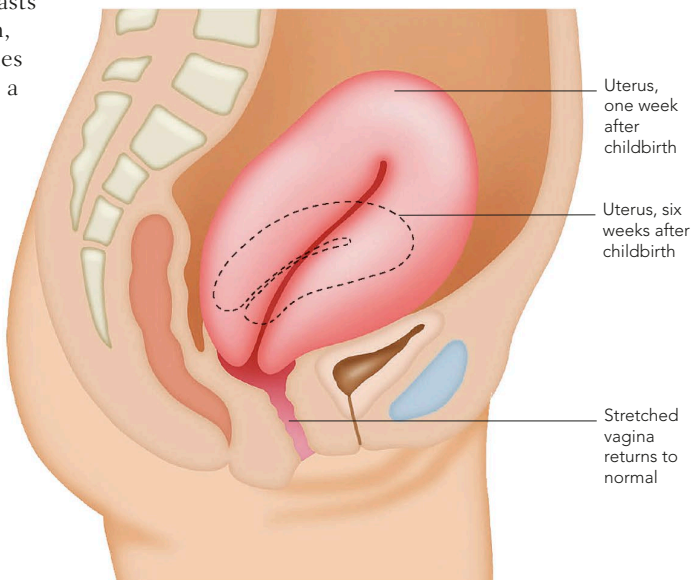
CHANGES IN THE MOTHER

Many physiological changes take place in the mother after birth, for which her body has prepared during pregnancy. The process of enhancing breast tissue in anticipation of breast-feeding begins early in pregnancy: the breasts enlarge visibly, and the alveoli in each of the milk-producing glands (lobules) swell and multiply. From three months into the pregnancy, the breasts can produce colostrum, a fluid rich in antibodies (which help to protect a

newborn from allergies and respiratory and gastrointestinal infections), water, protein, and minerals. After the birth, colostrum supplies a breast-fed baby with nutrition until the mother's milk begins to flow several days later. Soon after birth, the uterus begins to shrink to its pre-pregnancy size – a process that is helped by breast-feeding.

UTERUS SHRINKS

After delivery of the baby and the placenta in the second and third stages of labour, hormones in the mother's body cause her uterus and vagina to shrink back to their normal size and position in her body.



LACTATION

During pregnancy, lobules (milk-producing glands) increase in size and number in preparation for breast-feeding the baby. By the end of the first trimester, they can produce colostrum, the yellow fluid that provides antibodies to protect against allergies and gastrointestinal and respiratory infections in the newborn.

